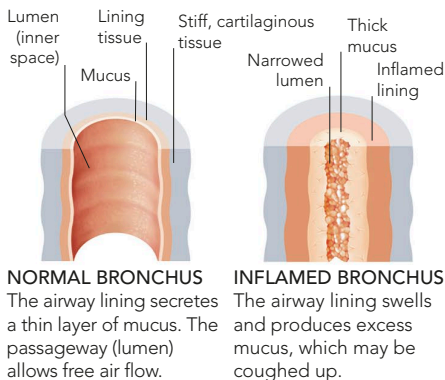


INFLUENZA

Influenza is primarily an upper respiratory tract infection, but it also has body-wide symptoms: raised temperature, sensations of being hot and sweaty and then cold with shivers, muscle aches, and exhaustion. Even after the main infection has cleared up, there may be lingering depression and fatigue. The influenza viruses are coded A, B, and C and are very contagious. Influenza A tends to produce regular outbreaks and can also affect domestic animals such as pigs, horses, and fowl. Influenza B usually causes more sporadic outbreaks in places where many people gather and interact. Influenza C is less likely to produce serious symptoms. The type A virus is most likely to change or mutate. People at risk of dangerous complications, such as the very young or elderly, can be vaccinated before the main risk time of the winter season. Because the virus can mutate, new vaccines are prepared annually.

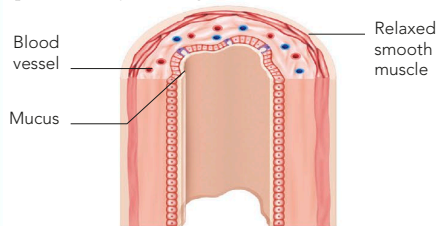
ACUTE BRONCHITIS

Bronchitis is inflammation of the larger airways (bronchi) in the lungs. The disorder may be a complication of a respiratory infection. Its acute form develops rapidly, with symptoms including a sputum-producing cough, tight chest, wheezing, and mild fever. Healthy adults usually recover in a few days.



ASTHMA

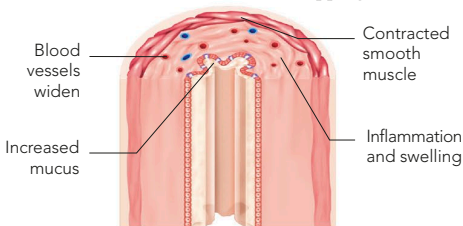
Asthma is an inflammatory lung disease that causes recurrent attacks of breathlessness and wheezing due to narrowed airways. Some people have the occasional slight episode; others are prone to severe and even life-threatening attacks. The muscle in the walls of the airways contracts spasmodically, causing constriction of the tubes.



HEALTHY AIRWAY

The bronchiole has relaxed smooth muscle in its walls and a thin coating of protective mucus covering the lining. The passage of air is unrestricted.

The narrowing is worsened by the secretion of excess mucus. Most cases develop in childhood and may be linked to allergy-based problems such as eczema. In many children, the trigger for an attack is an allergic reaction to a foreign substance, such as inhaled particles of pollen, animal hair, or house dust mite droppings.



ASTHMATIC AIRWAY

In an asthma attack, the muscle wall contracts and inflammation causes swelling of the airway lining. The mucus thickens, further narrowing the airway.